Chapter 6

‘Crane’ Bedi:
Prime Minister’s Car Towed Away

THE ASIAN GAMES HELD IN DELHI IN NOVEMBER-DECEMBER 1982 symbolized a prestigious landmark for India. And probably it was destiny that ensured that Kiran was at the helm of Delhi’s traffic police at that time. She was posted, almost against her choice, as DCP (Traffic) in October 1981. This was a responsibility given to her so close to the event, yet the most rewarding of Kiran’s career in which she displayed all the qualities of a fearless and indefatigable leader.

No one could have imagined that just within weeks of passionate and dedicated efforts, a young police officer, non-sparing in traffic enforcement, could win the hearts and minds of the people and be nicknamed ‘Crane Bedi’ for all time!

Kiran’s highly enthusiastic and virtually round-the-clock work drew out every bit of energy from her. This was because as soon as she began her road rounds every morning, she realized what a ‘snarling bear’ she had to grapple with in the form of Delhi traffic! She also had to draw up plans to regulate and control such traffic for the Asian games within the limited time at her disposal. To add to the chaotic traffic, nineteen sports stadia were being constructed all over the city and also many flyovers, thereby resulting in road blockages, diversions and the inevitable congestion. Delhi traffic was haphazard and completely out of gear. This was because the traffic police assignment was never considered important. There was no system of spot fining and no fear of effective enforcement due to which the traffic policeman hardly mattered. Hence, the traffic beat was more of a transaction/collection place for mutual benefits, while commuters muscled their own way through.

This position, which had the inherent potential for corrupt practices, was given to Kiran directly by the then lieutenant governor of Delhi, S. L. Khurana. She recalls when she was called to his office and told by him, rather suddenly: ‘Kiran I want you to be the Delhi Police traffic chief. You will manage the Asian games traffic. The games are a year away.’ Kiran was taken by surprise as it was being rumoured that someone else who was close to the then police commissioner would be chosen for this post. But obviously, the Delhi LG had a mind of his own. Kiran pointed out to the LG that she did not know much about the roads of Delhi and that she may not be the best choice at that juncture. But the LG had made up his mind. And he had his own reasons, the most important one being to check soaring corruption that was rampant in the traffic unit.

In order to meet the exacting demands of her new challenge, Kiran relied on her ever-caring mother to help her start her day by 5 a.m. She first cleared her office files by working till 7 a.m. All letters to be issued from her office were spoken into a dictaphone along with any instructions to be circulated among her staff. By 8 a.m. she was out on the roads in her white Ambassador car fitted with a wireless set and a loudspeaker. She held a microphone in her hand, through which she would give appropriate instructions, wherever needed, while being driven around the various localities of the